

interests. This is perhaps where the world got their first glimpse of “social networking.” There were hundreds of like-minded individuals talking and sharing information based on interests—in real-time. When file sharing came into IRC, it became a popular P2P activity, with people sharing information and music, making friends, and even visiting each other offline in the “real world,” so to speak.

Next came all the Instant Messengers, notably ICQ. Chat rooms and one-on-one chats made it even easier to build friendships with people all over the world. It obviously wasn’t long before Web sites took the cue, and dating sites came up. The most social and popular activity, finding prospective significant others, became a lot easier, with dating sites (matrimonial sites for India) going global.

As early as 1995, the first social networking site came up. Classmates.com was intelligently targeted at anyone who hadn’t kept in touch with school mates, and needless to say, became popular. This was followed by SixDegrees.com in 1997; it was based on the principle that everyone on planet Earth was separated only by six acquaintances.

Social networking as we know it really took off with Friendster.com, launched in 2002.

Today, social networking accounts for the majority of surfing done globally. Sites such as MySpace, Orkut, Hi5, Windows Live Spaces, Xanga, Facebook, Friendster, Classmates, Bebo, and many, many more, all boast of millions of users. MySpace, in particular, boasts of almost a whopping 200 million registered users! Orkut is very popular amongst us Indians, while more Indian sites seem to be coming up by the month.